

Social Media



COMMUNICATION AT WORK

In the Spiral16 scenario, Whitney Mathews explains how she uses social media in her position as social media manager.

Spiral16 is an informatic software company that builds products related to social media monitoring and analysis. One of the company's products, Spark®, monitors what people say online to help companies

- manage and protect their brands
- determine customer opinions
- spot potential public relations crises
- understand “language trends” through semantic analysis

Spiral16 helps companies make sense of the immense social media space by mapping the terrain of the Internet. This is done by visualizing near real-time results pulled from all categories of Web sites, including blogs, forums, news organizations, and videos. Spark assesses social media trends by accessing, studying, and reporting on public data on the Web. Some examples of Web sites Spark gathers information from include

- blogs
- online news organizations

Learning Objectives

When you complete this chapter, you will be able to

- Understand that social media can take many different forms, including Internet discussion forums, blogs, vlogs, podcasts, online pictures, videos, and wikis
- Understand that companies should create guidelines and ethical standards for employee use of social media
- Know that a blog, the shortened version of the words Web log, is created online and can include text, graphics, links to other Web sites, and video
- Use YouTube for presentations, announcements, news releases, training, video instructions, and marketing
- Ensure proper production values when shooting YouTube videos
- Follow rules for Twittetiquette
- Know that thousands of companies have Facebook sites
- Know that on their Facebook site, companies can host a corporate blog, provide access to Twitter entries, post company YouTube videos, show photographs of corporate employees, list upcoming events and/or product releases, and provide access to discussion forums
- Use social media in a company to communicate during a crisis situation
- Use the checklist to ensure correct use of social media on the job

- social network communities, including Facebook, MySpace, Flickr, Ning, and LinkedIn
- YouTube and Vimeo
- Reference Web sites, such as MSNMoney, YahooFinance, and Wikipedia
- Twitter

Spiral16 effectively uses social media to grow its business as it helps other companies and organizations connect with their audience's needs and interests.

Whitney Mathews, social media manager at Spiral16, has an interesting and varied job with numerous responsibilities. She often works 55 hours or more each week and rarely turns off her iPhone. "I even watch television with the remote in one hand and my iPhone in the other!" For Whitney, a typical workday consists of

- Researching Spiral16 every morning when she gets to work using "our software Spark." Whitney performs this research to find out what is being said about Spiral16 and to find out who is talking about the company. She then leaves blog posts in response to the commentary and thanks the people who have communicated about Spiral16. She also likes to let her coworkers know about the comments and "flags" entries for them.
- Updating case study research about clients.

- Writing entries on the company's blog or working on current projects. One recent project was a PowerPoint presentation for Spiral16's president who was making the presentation at a meeting in Chicago.
- Attending social networking events. These events include blog meetups or Tweetups with business professionals she has met through her social media connections.
- Participating in sponsorships with other companies or individuals through bartering. Whitney will monitor other events for free "as long as they put our logo in their literature." In this way, Whitney advertises her company.
- Attending social media conferences to network and to acquire content for the company blog.

According to Whitney, organization is a critical part of performing her job. She finds that the following tools are critical to her success:

- iPhone allows 24/7 access for Whitney.
- Spark gives Whitney the software capability to study the information found on the Web.
- She says, "My laptop has my whole work life on it."
- TweetDeck is an application designed around Twitter that filters Twitter information.

Why Is Social Media Important in the Workplace?

Social media has a growing impact in today's workplace. "Social network or blog sites are visited by three quarters of global consumers who go online" (Owyang). Many companies are discovering "the benefits of blogs, online video and social-networking sites" (Ranii). According to Marius Ciorte, senior manager of project management and office Web architecture at Oracle, using social media in the workplace makes employees approachable, allowing for transparent conversations with customers and quick response to customer concerns. Michael Brito, social media strategist for Intel, says that with social media, companies can "humanize their brand" and achieve a sense of community and participation with customers.

Sun Microsystems is one example of a company that is using social media channels to connect its customers and employees. According to Sumaya Kazi, senior social media manager at Sun Microsystems, employees at Sun are expected to participate in social networking (wikis, blogs, tweets, and Facebook). "It's part of their jobs" to build community, listen, share, learn, and communicate with each other and with their customers. Social media is such a large part of life at Sun that the company has created "social media ecosystems"—multiple avenues of connectivity. Recently, Sun employees participated in social media as follows:

- 5,426 Sun bloggers
- 4,437 Sun blogs (including group blogs)
- 71,000 contributors to wikis.sun.com
- 946,000 contributors to forums.sun.com
- 200 communities on Sun's Facebook site
- 5,240 followers on Sun's Twitter site

According to a study performed by the University of Massachusetts Dartmouth Center for Marketing Research, "500 of the fastest growing companies in the US [have] found that familiarity with and use of blogs, podcasting, wikis, online video and social networking has skyrocketed." Seventy-seven percent of the businesses that responded to this marketing research survey used social media in their business (Kirkpatrick).

Another important use of social media is crisis communication. The FBI states, "Social media is rivaling 911 services in crisis response and reporting. . . . Social media has emerged to be the first instance of communication about a crisis, trumping . . . police, firefighters, EMT, and journalists" (Wohlsen).

Here are two one-stop sites for breaking news about social media: *Social Media Today* (<http://socialmediatoday.com/>) provides "insight and host[s] lively debate about the tools, platforms, companies and personalities that are revolutionizing the way we consume information"; *Mashable* (<http://mashable.com>) provides "social media news and web tips."

What Is Social Media?

Social media can take many different forms, including Internet discussion forums, blogs, vlogs, podcasts, online videos, and wikis. A company can use a blog to transmit information about the company, its personnel, and its products and services. This communication can be delivered quickly and efficiently to an individual's smartphone, tablet, or laptop computer—anytime, anywhere. Social media, in combination with mobile communication, allows for real-time video instructions to be delivered through YouTube and information delivered through Twitter, Facebook, or LinkedIn, among others.

Through a Facebook wall, customers can post directly to the company and communicate with many different levels of management. Bill Brelsford, owner of Rebar Business Builders, says, “I believe the ‘cool’ factor lies not in the technology but in the fact that now I can have a conversation with someone like the president of a large corporation, something I would probably not be able to do without social media tools” (Goforth). Whitney Mathews, social media manager at Spiral16, says social media is the “new customer help line” (Mathews). See Table 1 for examples of social media.

TABLE 1 Examples of Social Media

Blogger—a blog publishing system Delicious—a social bookmarking or social tagging Web service for storing and sharing Web bookmarks Digg—a social news Web site allowing users to submit Internet links and stories, vote, and comment on submitted stories Facebook—a social networking Web site Open Diary—a blog publishing system Photobucket—an image and video hosting Web site Pinterest—a social photo and information sharing Web site Plaxo—an online address book and social networking service Plurk—a social networking, microblogging service Revver—a video sharing Web site Yahoo! Groups—an electronic mailing list and Internet forum Flickr—an image and video hosting Web site	Friendster—a social networking Web site Google Groups—a service from Google allowing discussions about common interests Jaiku—a social networking, microblogging service Justin.tv—a network of channels for online live video streaming Second Life—a virtual world Skype—a software application that lets users make telephone calls over the Internet SmugMug—a digital photo sharing Web site Twitter—a social networking, microblogging service TypePad—a blog publishing service Ustream.tv—a network of channels for live video streaming of online events YouTube—a video sharing Web site allowing users to upload and share video clips	LinkedIn—a business-oriented social networking site LiveJournal—a blog publishing system Meetup—an online social networking site that facilitates group meetings and allows members to find and join groups unified by common interests MySpace—a social networking Web site vBulletin—an Internet site for forums and community blogs Vimeo—a social networking site that supports video sharing, video storage, and user comments Wikis—community Web sites, such as Wetpaint, PBWiki, and Wikispaces, that allow for collaborative creation and editing of Web pages WordPress—an open source blog publishing application Yelp—a social networking online opinion site for user reviews Zoomr—a Web site for sharing digital photos and text messages
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Guidelines of Social Media Usage on the Job

Companies might hope that their employees’ use of social media will be ethical and professional. However, this assumption could lead to problems. Without precise social media guidelines, employees could disclose confidential information or trade secrets, create public relations problems, or damage a company’s image.

To avoid such situations, companies should create guidelines for employee use of social media. Following is a suggested social media policy adapted from the *National Law Journal* (Jackson).

EXAMPLE ►**Corporate Social Media Policy**

- Not following the company's guidelines for social media can lead to disciplinary action, including termination.
- Disclosing your employer's trade secrets or confidential and proprietary information is not allowed.
- Keep company logos and registered trademarks off your blogs.
- Do not mention your company in social media unless it is required as part of your job responsibilities.
- Do not post social media entries during business hours, unless this is part of your job responsibilities.
- Do not post work-related complaints.
- Do not use your company e-mail address when registering for social media sites. This could lead to viruses, spam, or illegal hacking.
- Do not post false information about your company, colleagues, or customers.
- Never use social media to harass, disparage, discriminate, or defame the company, colleagues, or customers.
- Take professional responsibility for your social media postings.
- If you mention your company in any social media postings, include a disclaimer stating that the views expressed are personal and do not reflect the opinions or policies of the company.

Types of Social Media

Although social media involves many different channels of delivery, this chapter focuses on the following:

- blogging
- YouTube
- Twitter
- Facebook

Understanding these types of social media will allow you to participate in online communities and incorporate social media into your workplace.

Blogging for Business

Jonathan Schwartz, president and chief operating officer of Sun Microsystems, says that blogging is a “must-have tool for every executive,” as important as a smartphone and an e-mail account (Kharif). Bill Gates, Microsoft's CEO, says that blogs could be a better way for firms to communicate with customers, staff, and partners than e-mail and Web sites. “More than 700 Microsoft employees are already using blogs to keep people up to date with their projects” (“Gates backs blogs for business”). Marc Cuban, owner of the Dallas Mavericks basketball team, has a blog (Ray). IBM created “the largest corporate blogging initiative” by encouraging its 320,000 employees to become active bloggers with the goal of achieving “thought leadership” in the global information technology market (Foremski). Nike launched an “adverblog” to market its products. What is “blogging,” and why are so many influential companies and business leaders becoming involved in this social media channel?

Blogging—A Definition. A blog, the shortened version of the words Web log, is created online and can include text, graphics, links to other Web sites, and video. Blogs not only allow

but also encourage input from many readers. Daily, millions of people use blogs to publish their thoughts. Though many blogs feature text, blogs take different forms, including the following:

- vlogs—the posting of videos through RSS feeds (Really Simple Syndication or Rich Site Summary) to create miniprograms, such as seen on YouTube.
- podcasting—news, market information, product announcements, public service announcements, how-to videos, photographs, audio files, and more can be conveyed through podcast blogs. The term “podcast” is a combination of the words “iPod” and “broadcast.”
- microblogging—brief text, usually less than 200 characters. Facebook and MySpace, two popular blog sites, include microblogging features.
- Twitter—a free microblogging service. Users can send short tweets or updates limited to 140 characters to cell phones or other blog sites.

Reasons for Blogging. Following are reasons why companies blog.

Communicate with colleagues. Chris Winfield, president of an online marketing company, says that he uses blogging to improve “communication flow to his employees” (Ray). Many companies encourage their employees to use blogging for project updates, issue resolutions, and company announcements. The engineering department at Disney ABC Cable Networks Group uses blogs “to log help desk inquiries” (Li).

Communicate with customers. In contrast to private, intranet-based blogs used for internal corporate communication, companies also have public blogs. Through public blogs, a company can initiate question/answer forums, respond to customer concerns, allow customers to communicate with each other, create interactive newsletters, introduce new products and services, and build rapport with customers, vendors, and stakeholders.

Improve search engine rankings. Marketing is a key attraction of corporate blogs. A blog post using keywords, allowing for comments and responses, and providing references and links to other sites, tends to rank in the top 10 to 20 listings in Internet search engines (Ray).

Network through syndication. To access a Web site, a reader must know the URL or use a search engine, such as Google. In contrast, blogs can be distributed directly to the end users through a Web feed. The writers of a blog can syndicate their content. Then, through the Web feed, readers can subscribe to the blog. Syndication makes Web feeds available for people to access. By using feed programs, such as RSS or Atom, bloggers can syndicate their blogs or be notified when topics of interest are published. Thus, blogs can be very personalized, essentially delivered to your door on a moment’s notice.

Track public opinion. Trackback features, available from many blog services, let companies track blog usage. Tracking lets companies monitor their brand impact and learn what customers are saying (good news or bad news) about their products or services.

Guidelines for Effective Corporate Blogging. If you and your company decide to enter the blogosphere, the world of blogging, follow these guidelines.

Identify your audience. As with all technical communication, audience recognition and involvement are crucial. Before blogging, decide what topics you want to focus on, what your unique spin will be, what your goals are in using a blog, and who your blog might appeal to.

Achieve customer contact. Blogs are innately personal. Take advantage of this feature. Make your blogs fun and informal. You can give your blog personality and encourage

customer outreach by including corporate news, personnel biographies, question/answer forums, updates, an opportunity to add comments, as well as information about products and services (Ray). In addition, make sure the blog is interactive, allowing for readers to comment, check out new links, or add links.

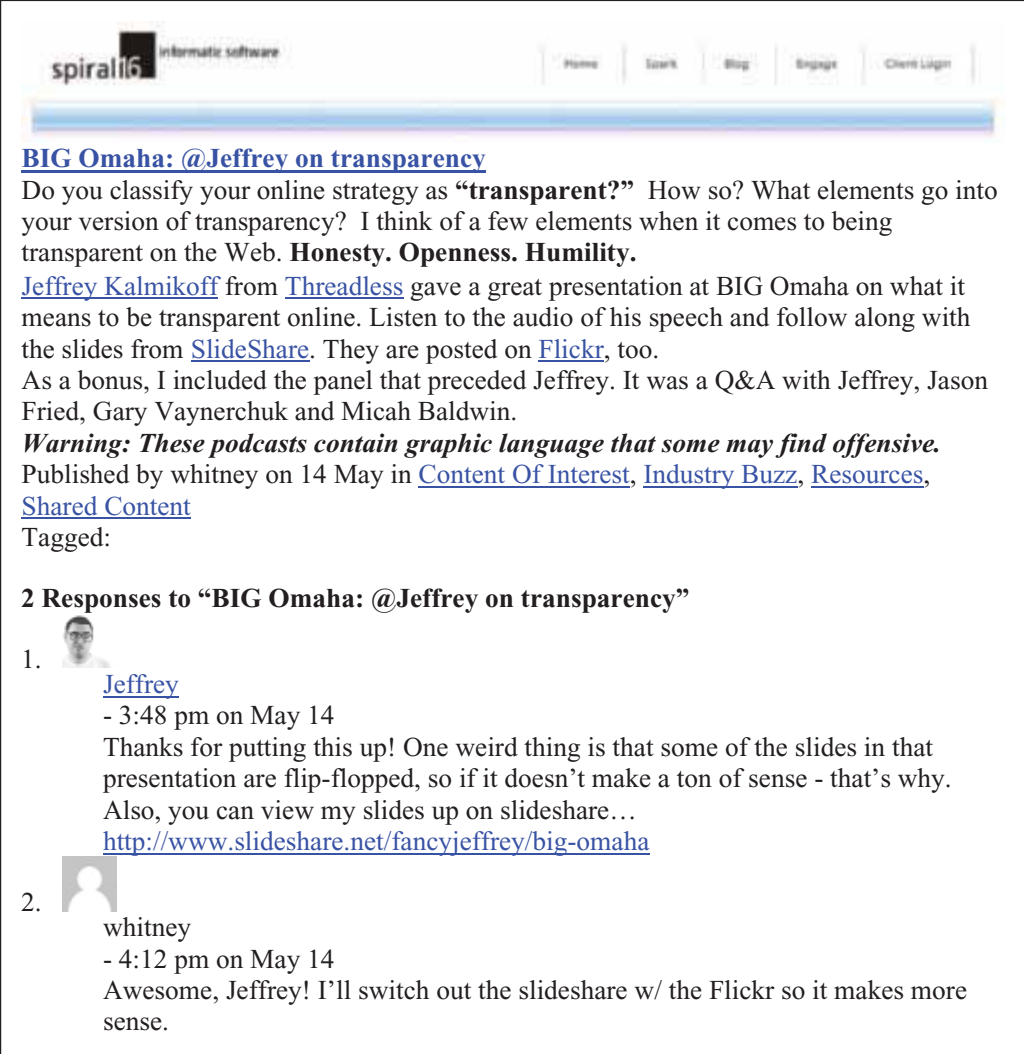
Start blogrolling. Once you have determined audience and blog location, it's time to start blogrolling. Start talking. Not only do you need to start the dialogue by adding content to your blog, but also you want to link your blog to other sites (Wuorio "Blogging").

Keep it fresh. Avoid a stale blog. By posting frequently (daily or weekly) and responding quickly to comments and criticism, you encourage readers to access your site and return to it often.

Develop guidelines for corporate blog usage. Because blogs encourage openness from customers as well as employees, a company must establish guidelines for corporate blog usage.

Figure 1 is a sample blog from Spiral16.

FIGURE 1 Sample Blog



spiral16 informatic software

Home Search Blog Engage Client Login

BIG Omaha: @Jeffrey on transparency

Do you classify your online strategy as “transparent?” How so? What elements go into your version of transparency? I think of a few elements when it comes to being transparent on the Web. **Honesty. Openness. Humility.**

Jeffrey Kalmikoff from Threadless gave a great presentation at BIG Omaha on what it means to be transparent online. Listen to the audio of his speech and follow along with the slides from SlideShare. They are posted on Flickr, too.

As a bonus, I included the panel that preceded Jeffrey. It was a Q&A with Jeffrey, Jason Fried, Gary Vaynerchuk and Micah Baldwin.

Warning: These podcasts contain graphic language that some may find offensive.

Published by whitney on 14 May in Content Of Interest, Industry Buzz, Resources, Shared Content

Tagged:

2 Responses to “BIG Omaha: @Jeffrey on transparency”

1.  Jeffrey
- 3:48 pm on May 14
Thanks for putting this up! One weird thing is that some of the slides in that presentation are flip-flopped, so if it doesn't make a ton of sense - that's why. Also, you can view my slides up on slideshare...
<http://www.slideshare.net/fancyjeffrey/big-omaha>

2.  whitney
- 4:12 pm on May 14
Awesome, Jeffrey! I'll switch out the slideshare w/ the Flickr so it makes more sense.

Source: Courtesy of Spiral16

YouTube and Business

YouTube is increasingly important in business to communicate with a technologically adept consumer.

Why Should Businesses Have a YouTube Presence? Another social media opportunity for a business is YouTube. YouTube is a way for a company to connect with the customer. Because television, radio, and print advertising have become very expensive, companies can benefit from a more affordable means of advertising and marketing products and services. YouTube videos can be posted for free and allow businesses to reach millions of potential customers. “YouTube is a video sharing website allowing members to upload, share, and comment on a large database of videos. In one month alone, YouTube had a staggering 2.4 billion page views. Online video is hot” (Zahorsky). Research performed by the Kelsey Group “revealed that 59 percent of survey respondents watch online video. Emarketer estimates online video ad spending to reach over \$700 million” annually (Zahorsky).

What Should Businesses Post on YouTube? A business can benefit from posting the following on YouTube:

- Presentations from executives to discuss finances, corporate activities, company performance, and so forth
- Announcements of important corporate news
- News releases of company activities
- Training for purchasers of products
- Videotapes of consumer questions and help-desk answers with procedural steps
- Marketing of new products with pictures
- Events such as corporate celebrations, meetings, and other activities
- Instructional videos showing how to use products

Guidelines for Shooting Videos to Post on YouTube. You have to shoot a video that people actually want to watch. A picture might be worth a thousand words, but if no one sees the picture, then you’ve wasted time. To shoot a successful video and ensure “proper production values,” do the following (Miller):

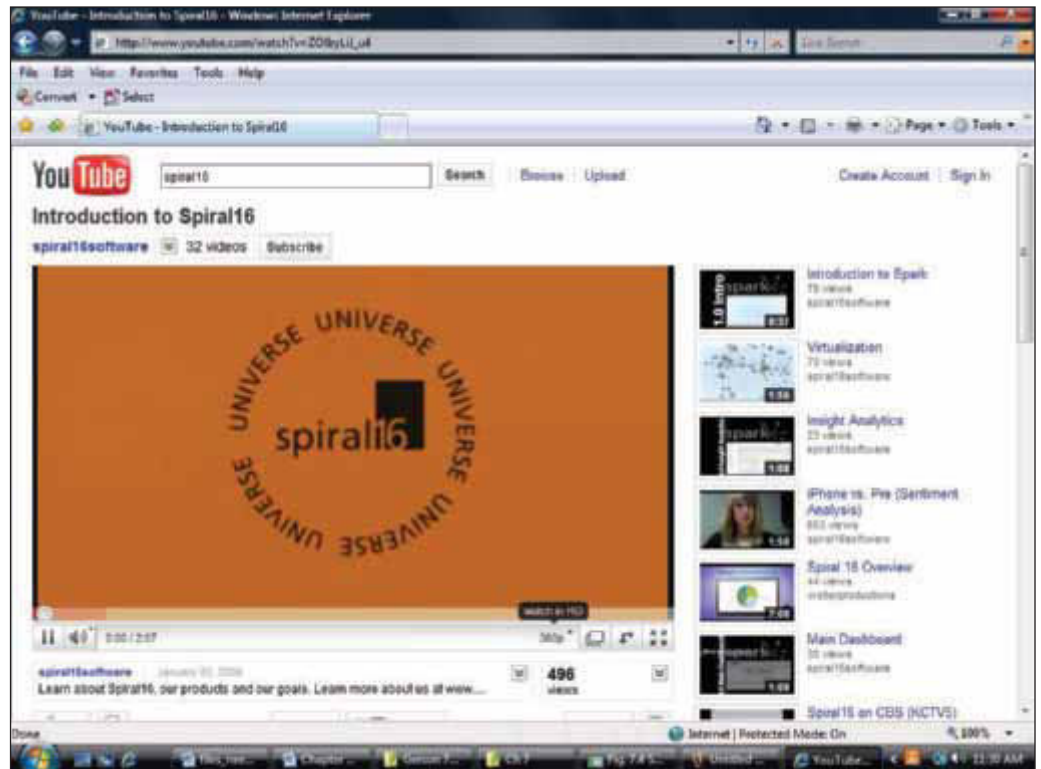
- Title your video and use appropriate subtitles periodically in the video.
- Include the company name and contact information such as a telephone number and the Web site URL.
- Use onscreen graphics to enliven the video.
- Edit a longer video into short segments. YouTube allows videos 10 minutes long.
- Keep focused “on one key message with the strongest lead benefit,” and avoid attempting to cover all your products or all your services (Zahorsky).
- Avoid plagiarism by creating your own content. “Before using music clips, television clips, or movie clips, you need to get permission to do so. If you fail to get permission, you are, essentially, stealing someone’s work” (Brewer).

See Figure 2 for a sample YouTube screen courtesy of Spiral16.

Tweeting for Business

Businesses rely increasingly on Twitter for corporate communication and to reach the consumer.

What’s Twitter? What’s a Tweet? To use Twitter, you tweet. According to Wikipedia, “Twitter is a social networking and micro-blogging service that allows its users to send and read other users’ updates.” These messages are called tweets. Each tweet is a text-based post of up to 140 characters. Twitter is a free service that lets you subscribe to, share, or follow as many Twitter messages as you like.

FIGURE 2 YouTube Screen

Source: Courtesy of Spiral16

Jessica Vascellaro of the *Wall Street Journal* writes, “Email has had a good run as king of communications. But its reign is over. In its place, a new generation of services is starting to take hold—services like Twitter...[promise] to profoundly rewrite the way we communicate” (Vascellaro R1). The primary reason for this change is access. Twitter is a distributed communication system, and you don’t need to open a Web browser to access this service. Instead, you and your readers (called “followers”) can receive tweets in a variety of ways. “People download . . . programs like Twitterific, Feedalizr or Twinkle, they get the updates on their cellphones as text messages, or they use something like PocketTweets, Tweetie or iTweet for the iPhone” (Pogue). If you want to access tweets through your desktop or laptop, Twitterific opens up as a “tall, narrow window at the side of the screen. Incoming tweets scroll up” (Pogue).

Tweets don’t have to be intrusive, either. Not everyone needs to read what you tweet. You can be more discerning by sending a direct message, which only one follower sees versus responding with a public tweet. Tweets can be sent directly to your RSS reader, and you can republish (retweet) a stream of content on your Web site or blog. Figure 3 defines commonly used Twitter terms.

Why Do Companies Use Twitter? Restaurants can tweet their daily specials, realtors can tweet new homes on the market, and a chamber of commerce could tweet about local city events and promotions. Companies can accomplish the following with Twitter:

- Direct people’s attention to corporate news, products, services, and events.
- Give customers and coworkers a forum, allowing a company to study concerns, manage issues, initiate discussions, answer questions, and respond to complaints.
- Assist with business development—promotional and marketing collateral.

FIGURE 3 Definitions of Commonly Used Twitter Terms

Follower	People who read your tweets on Twitter
Retweet	When you copy someone else's tweet or republish a stream of tweets
Tweet	A single Twitter message
Tweetdeck	Software that runs on your desktop. You can post tweets from it, respond to tweets, set up searches, and get updates in real time.
Twetie	The Twitter application for iPhone and iPod Touch
Tweet scan	Twitter's search tool
Tweeple	People who tweet
Twellow	A Twitter directory (something like the Yellow pages)
Twirl	A desktop application that updates incoming tweets
Twitturly	A service for tracking URLs that people are talking about

- Add to and improve customer service. Through Twitter, you can send service updates and respond to customer concerns. Best Buy, for example, has created “Twelpforce,” a customer-service team to answer customer questions about products and services.
- Help you show the “human” side of your company (tell what employees are doing and show how your company is involved in charitable activities).
- Allow dispersed work teams to communicate quickly with each other. For example, Handmark is a leading developer of mobile apps. Handmark employees work in Kansas City, Dallas, and Palo Alto. Due to their dispersed work locales, employees can't just walk down the hall to discuss projects. Paul Reddick, CEO of Handmark, says he and his coworkers use Twitter for “virtual cube talk” (Reddick).

Which Companies Have Twitter Sites? Table 2 shows companies with Twitter sites, their uses of these sites, and a few examples of tweets.

Rules for Twittetiquette. The bottom line to etiquette of any sort is treating people with respect. After that essential consideration, following are rules for etiquette when using Twitter—Twittetiquette.

1. Use services like Twitter Search to find who might be writing about you or your company.
2. Don't tweet all day while at work. That's not an effective use of your time or corporate time.
3. Don't use Twitter just as another channel for advertising. It should have a more personal, social media component—people talking to people.

DOT.COM UPDATES

Check out these URLs to learn more about Twitter:

- Brogan, Chriss. “50 Ideas on Using Twitter for Business.” <http://www.chrisbrogan.com/50-ideas-on-using-twitter-for-business/>
- Brooks, Rich. “How to Use Twitter For Business.” <http://www.flyte.biz/resources/newsletters/08/06-twitter-for-business.php>
- King, Rachael. “How Companies Use Twitter to Bolster Their Brands.” http://www.businessweek.com/technology/content/sep2008/tc2008095_320491.htm
- Pogue, David. “Twittering Tips for Beginners.” http://www.nytimes.com/2009/01/15/technology/personaltech/15pogue-email.html?_r=2&sq=Pogue%20twitter&st=Search&scp=4&page_wanted=all

TABLE 2 Companies Using Twitter

Companies Using Twitter	Purposes	Tweet Examples
JetBlue (http://twitter.com/jetblue).	Respond to customers' questions	Q: "Which destination would you pick for a short vacation?: Las Vegas (1) or New Orleans (2)?" A: "2 to 1 in favor of Vegas for a short trip after the initial volley of replies."
TheHomeDepot (http://twitter.com/thehomedepot)	Respond to customer concerns	"Sorry you didn't get the attention you deserved. We'd still like to help with your project. Can I help?"
Dell (www.dell.com/twitter)	Highlight individual Dell employee activities	"RT@LionelatDell Dell donates \$5 to Susan G. Komen for the Cure for each Promise Pink laptop we sell. Lots of options (http://twitter.com/richardatdell)."
SouthwestAir (http://twitter.com/SouthwestAir)	Provide links to online articles for more information	"Did you know Southwest Pilots mentor thousands of students in science, math, geography, and writing? Read more: http://tinyurl.com/bpf6wb ."
GM (http://twitter.com/GMblogs)	Share customer comments	"Retweeting @WarLordwrites: I've been using the GM OnStar Navigation system. I'm pleased. GM got this very right!"
M&Ms (http://twitter.com/msgreen)	Update company promotional activities	"Need a little va-va-voom in your love life? Tell me why over at www.mms.com/green and you could win a romantic Paris getaway!"
HRBlock (http://twitter.com/hrblock)	Build rapport	"Happy to hear it went well! It's a relief to have your taxes filed isn't it? You're ahead of me ;)"

4. Separate business from fun. Have two Twitter accounts: one that is strictly business and one that is for friends, family, and fun.
5. Don't tweet in anger. A tweet sent in anger can be read by thousands of people. They might not appreciate your haste and negativity. In contrast, positive interaction with a company representative could have a more positive impact (Brogan, Mathews).

See Figure 4 for a sample Twitter page courtesy of Spiral16.

Facebook

In addition to other social media sites, businesses use Facebook for corporate communications.

Business Uses for Facebook. Why would a business want to have a Facebook presence? Perhaps the greatest reason for companies to use Facebook is the enormous growth of this social media site, as shown in Table 3.

"Facebook's user base has expanded beyond college students" (Goforth D15). As shown in Figure 5, though the largest increase in total Facebook users is the 18 to 25 year cohort, the second largest rise is in the 26 to 34 age range. In fact, "45% of Facebook's US audience is now 26 years old or older," and the "fastest growing segment" of Facebook users is "women over 55" ("Fastest Growing Demographic on Facebook: Women Over 55").

With such large numbers of potential customers, a company can use Facebook as a one-stop location to market products or services, create brand recognition, recruit new employees, and connect with the customer on a personal basis. On their Facebook site, companies can host their corporate blog, provide access to their Twitter entries, post company YouTube videos, show photographs of corporate employees, list upcoming events

FIGURE 4 Sample Twitter Page

Source: Courtesy of Spiral16

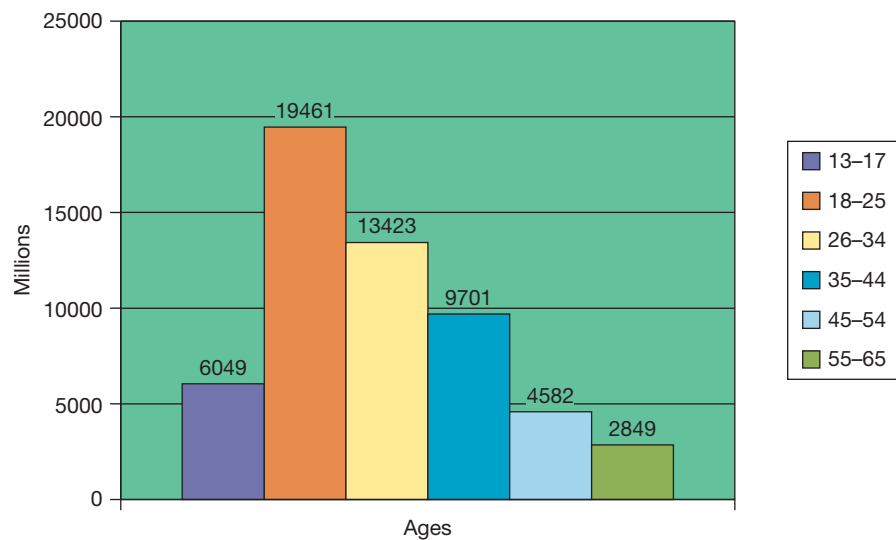
TABLE 3 Facebook Statistics

People on Facebook	Facebook has more than 845 million active users.
Activity on Facebook	Over one billion Facebook posts per day 2.7 billion likes/comments per day Over 100 billion friendships 250 million photos uploaded each day (Pring)
Global Reach	More than 70 translations are available on the site. About 70% of Facebook users are outside the United States. ("Statistics")

and product releases, and provide access to discussion forums. Businesses use Facebook in a variety of ways, including the following:

- Collaborating in teams—sharing documents and tasks and collaborating on projects
- Uploading PowerPoint slides to share presentations, tutorials, and demonstrations
- Conducting polls to find out end-user needs and preferences
- Managing a crisis by providing updates and responding to customer concerns

Guidelines for Businesses Participating on Facebook. For you and your company to participate on Facebook, follow these guidelines.

FIGURE 5 Total Facebook Users in the United States by Age Cohort

Create a clear business goal. What do you hope to accomplish in your company's Facebook site? Do you want to sell, promote charitable activities, share information about employees, show videos of how-to tutorials, allow for give-and-take with customers through blog entries, and so forth? Determine a plan before going online on Facebook ("Bosses").

FAQs: Virtual Worlds in the Workplace

Q: What's Second Life?

A: Created by Linden Research, Inc., Second Life® is a 3-D virtual world, a digital, social media continent populated by avatars. To access this virtual world, all you need to do is download a free Second Life (SL) viewer application, which runs on Macs, PCs, and Linux servers. You create your avatar (your virtual self) and "teleport" into alternative worlds.

Q: Why would you want to enter this virtual world?

A: SL provides its end users and its host organizations a multitude of technical communication values. Here's a list of reasons why organizations use SL.

- **Marketing.** Companies use SL to tell customers about new products and hold virtual events with guest speakers. In SL, a company can build brand recognition.
- **Training.** With SL, you and your avatar can be involved in virtual hands-on tutorials. SL is an especially valuable tool for training when employees and clients are geographically dispersed, when actual equipment is expensive, and when situations are dangerous. In a virtual world, machines can't break and no one can be injured following a procedure.
- **Modeling, monitoring, and product testing.** Whether it's a new car, software product, machine, or a hotel resort, it can be cheaper to create an SL version and get feedback from potential end users than it would be to build an actual prototype in RL (real life).
- **Providing customer service.** IBM has opened an SL business center staffed by an international core of IBM sales representatives. In this virtual business center, customers can buy hardware and software. Plus, these avatars of actual clients can get answers to their computing questions and solutions to their business problems.
- **Virtual conferencing.** You can travel to off-site conferences, engage in webinars, participate in teleconferences, or attend a virtual conference in SL.

SOCIAL MEDIA CHECKLIST

- | | |
|---|---|
| _____ 1. Have you considered your audience's needs in your social media communication? | _____ 6. Have you considered ethical standards when using social media? |
| _____ 2. If you are using social media, how will you engage your audience and encourage participation in the blog, tweet, or Facebook site? | _____ 7. Did you review your communication for grammar, punctuation, or spelling errors? |
| _____ 3. If you are tweeting, have you limited your tweet to 140 characters? | _____ 8. If you have used material such as pictures, video, or words created by someone other than yourself, have you linked to the source or provided copyright information? |
| _____ 4. If you are using Facebook, have you developed a corporate plan? | _____ 9. Are you updating your blog posts frequently to keep the information fresh and current? |
| _____ 5. If you have created a video to post to YouTube, have you followed the guidelines, such as limited length, appropriate subject matter, titles and subtitles, contact information, and so forth? | _____ 10. Do you avoid spending excessive amounts of work time communicating via social media? |

Keep it fresh. You should update your Facebook profile consistently. Add new videos, new blog postings, new tweets, new information about company products and services, and news about company activities.

Add links to social media tools. Your company's Facebook site will be enhanced by other social media tools such as Twitter, YouTube videos, your company's blog, LinkedIn, etc.

Create reasonable conduct policies with employees. Write down and disseminate corporate policies for Facebook usage regarding security, confidentiality, and personal conduct online. "This way staff will be less likely to get an unpleasant surprise when they find out their employer doesn't approve of something they said or did" ("Facing").

When using social media sites such as Facebook, you must be ethical, honest, and represent your company respectfully. Consider the following guidelines before you post on Facebook:

- Always write truthfully about yourself or your company.
- Do not disclose confidential information about the company.
- Post photographs that represent employees in a professional manner.
- Avoid links to unprofessional, inappropriate, or personal sites.
- Post videos that are short and professional.
- Respond to public inquiries on the site immediately (within 24 hours of the posting).
- Update the work-related information on the Facebook site frequently.
- Avoid wasting work time with frequent postings of a personal nature.
- Avoid endorsing other people or companies unless your company approves.
- Do not post other people's writing without getting permission.

The Writing Process at Work

Effective communication follows a process of prewriting, writing, and rewriting. To illustrate the importance of the writing process in social media, look at how Whitney Mathews used prewriting, writing, and rewriting to create an effective blog entry for Spiral16.

Prewriting

Figure 6 illustrates Whitney Mathews' listing to gather and organize data for her blog entry for Spiral16.

FIGURE 6 Listing for a Blog Entry

1. What do I want the readers to learn about social media from my blog?
2. Where should people begin when they use social media?
3. What can the different departments in a company contribute to the use of social media?
4. What questions should be asked of the different departments to learn more about their use of social media with customers?
5. What do we hope to accomplish with social media?

Writing

Figure 7 is Whitney's draft of the blog entry that she wrote. She then thought about redesign issues to revise the text.

FIGURE 7 Whitney's Draft of the Blog Entry with Her Thoughts on Revision

I'll add headings and subheadings to help our readers navigate the text more easily.

I'll add hypertext links to help our readers find the original sources.

I'll break the text into smaller chunks, smaller paragraphs for easier access.

This paragraph would be much more reader friendly if I bulletized the questions.

A graphic would be a great way to show how we at Spiral16 help our readers visualize data. I'll try one of our bubble charts that show connections between data points.

One of the toughest things for companies to grasp when building a social media strategy is that they need to write the definition for their own success. When it comes to social media, objectives are different for everyone. That's the point. You can take your message to your audience in a way that fits what you want to achieve. We've talked about this before on the blog, but it's becoming more important as more companies create legit strategies.

So, if we come to a demo and ask what you are looking for when it comes to social media monitoring, take a second to think it through. Define your own goals and objectives. If you have no idea where to start, head to the whiteboard and have an old-fashioned brainstorming session. Bring a representative from every department. They will all have different ideas and voices on the value of your results. If they (or you) need a better understanding of why social media and monitoring matters. Also, if each department with a valuable interest has access to your data, it can keep your company on the same page while satisfying individual needs. Sales can identify potential clients, marketing can form strategy around results, communications can respond quickly to crises, and HR can police potential problems with employees. All these different departments can get these insights from the same data set.

Ask the group questions like the following: Do you respond to your audience online? If yes, are you satisfied with your response time? Do you want to improve customer service? What about sales? Do you want to increase your brand loyalty? Should you monitor specific campaigns or just your overall presence? What are some of your goals? What are suggestions you give to clients when it comes to developing strategy?

Rewriting

See Figure 8 for Whitney's successful blog entry from Spiral16.

FIGURE 8 Whitney's Blog Entry for Spiral16

New rule: You must define your objectives. In my experience, one of the toughest things for companies to grasp when building a social media strategy is that they need to write the definition for their own success.

When it comes to social media, **objectives are different for everyone.** That's the point. You can take your message to your audience in a way that fits what you want to achieve.

We've talked about this before on the blog (see [Three Steps for SocMed Solution Shopping](#)), but it's becoming more important as more companies create legit strategies.

So, if we come to a demo and ask what you are looking for when it comes to social media monitoring, take a second to think it through. **Define your own goals and objectives.**

If you have no idea where to start, head to the whiteboard and have an old-fashioned brainstorming session. **Bring a representative from every department** (sales, marketing, HR, etc.). They will all have different ideas and voices on the value of your results. If they (or you) need a better understanding of why social media and monitoring matters, check out our [recent presentation given at Magnet Interactive](#).

Also, if each department with a valuable interest has access to your data, it can keep your company on the same page while satisfying individual needs. Sales can identify potential clients, marketing can form strategy around results, communications can respond quickly to crises, and HR can police potential problems with employees. All these different departments can get these insights from the same data set.

Ask the group questions like . . .

- Do you respond to your audience online?
- If yes, are you satisfied with your response time?
- Do you want to improve customer service?
- What about sales?
- Do you want to increase your brand loyalty?
- Should you monitor specific campaigns or just your overall presence?
- . . . Or both?

The list goes on . . .

Make it clear what you want, and your monitoring software should be flexible enough to give you what you need.

What are some of your goals? What are suggestions you give to clients when it comes to developing strategy?



Source: Published by Whitney on 18 May in *Content Of Interest, Industry Buzz*

CHAPTER HIGHLIGHTS

1. Social media can take many different forms, including Internet discussion forums, blogs, vlogs, podcasts, online pictures, videos, and wikis.
2. Companies should create guidelines for employee use of social media.
3. A blog, the shortened version of the words Web log, is created online and can include text, graphics, links to other Web sites, and video.
4. YouTube is good for presentations, announcements, news releases, training, video instructions, and marketing.
5. Ensure proper production values when shooting YouTube videos.
6. Follow rules for Twittetiquette.
7. Thousands of companies have Facebook sites.
8. Link to your sources so you can avoid plagiarizing content.
9. On their Facebook site, companies can host their corporate blog, provide access to their Twitter entries, post company YouTube videos, show photographs of corporate employees, list upcoming events and/or product releases, and provide access to discussion forums.
10. Companies can use social media to communicate during a crisis situation.

APPLY YOUR KNOWLEDGE



CASE STUDY

S&L Engineering has been working on the construction of a multi-purpose site that would inhabit five blocks in downtown Los Angeles. The proposed site includes a boutique hotel, office space, condos, and retail shops. However, the project has met financial and legal problems that have negatively impacted the construction schedule. The project is two years behind schedule. Although 60 percent complete, the construction company that S&L hired has filed for bankruptcy. S&L has hired a new construction company that promises to complete the project in 18 months.

S&L Engineering needs to bring the community up to date on the status of the project. This includes damage control, because S&L wants to be a good neighbor to other businesses and residents who work and live near the construction site.

To accomplish their communication goals, S&L plans to do the following:

- a. Post a YouTube video of S&L's CEO speaking to the public about the project's challenges.
- b. Write a tweet announcing the status of the project.
- c. Post a blog entry from the construction manager of the building site, detailing plans for the project's completion.
- d. Post a Facebook wall entry about the new construction company (its local reputation and its plans for hiring from the local labor force).

Assignment

What content should be included in each of the above communication channels? Write the scripts for a, b, c, and d.

INDIVIDUAL AND TEAM PROJECTS

Facebook

1. Create a Facebook site for your college or technical communication class.
2. Review the Facebook sites of various businesses, governmental organizations, or industries. What do these sites have in common? What is unique to each site you visit? What is each company trying to accomplish in their Facebook site? How would you improve a site if you were the social media manager of this organization or company?

Twitter

After reading the following scenarios, respond to each companies' communication need by writing a 140-character tweet.

1. Your bank, Hearth and Home Savings and Loan, has new, low rates for mortgages (3.5 percent for 30-year loans—this is the lowest rate for home loans in over 30 years) and high rates for certificates of deposit (2.5 percent for three year CDs—CDs have been higher in the past, but recent rates have been much lower). Market these benefits to your bank's customers by sending a tweet.
2. At a recent X-Games motorcycle jumps and tricks competition, hosted by the EnVi Hotel in Las Vegas, Nevada, a rider, Jason Whitworth, performed a first-ever trick, which he called the "double loop Superman kick out." Jason rides your company's top-of-the-line motorcycle, the Turbo ZZ210, and wears your company's gear (helmet, boots, gloves, knee pads, and jumpsuit). To inform your company's audience of this new trick and to market your brand, send a tweet.
3. Four employees of your internationally marketed fast-food restaurant Hot Wings & Cool Things, created a video of themselves acting inappropriately in one of your restaurants. Posted on YouTube, they can be seen eating food from customers' trays and using cooking utensils in an unhealthy manner. Yes, you fired the employees and created new rules of appropriate behavior, incorporated into your training manuals, but still, you must manage this publicity crisis. Write a tweet to your international audience in which you confront bad publicity quickly and show how you manage poor employee behavior.
4. Your software company is rolling out a new product, a software program that will help potential college students apply for college loans, write their letters of application, and gather all application materials in a single portfolio file. To help customers use this new software, your company is planning a free-to-the-public informational webinar on March 11. The webinar will provide hands-on tutorials for using the new software and provide a "virtual" help desk for questions and answers. Share this update with potential customers by writing a tweet.
5. Today at 11:00 a.m., your city of Greenwood Springs experienced a major explosion at a chemical plant downtown. This led to over 50 injuries, closed streets (Elm Street going north and south from 45th Street to 91st Street), a portion of a closed highway (from Highway 62 to the I-48 southbound exit), and pollution problems due to heavy smoke. As city manager, you want to quickly inform your city residents of this crisis situation. Write a tweet to share the news, to warn residents, and to provide updates on traffic detours.

YouTube

1. Access a YouTube instructional video and analyze ways in which it succeeds or could be improved. Base your comments on the guidelines provided in this chapter. Write an e-mail message to your professor with a summary of your findings.
2. Create a company, product, or service. Write a script for a YouTube video that introduces or markets the new company, product, or service.

PROBLEM-SOLVING THINK PIECES

1. Check out Stonyfield Farm's blog site at <http://stonyfield.typepad.com/bovine/>. This site says, "Welcome to the bovine bugle."

Assignment

Read entries from the blog site. Then answer these questions:

- What are Stonyfield's goals in creating this blog?
 - How does this blog relate to corporate business?
 - If you were hired by a company of your choice, what storylines would your blogs feature and why?
2. Sanya Guptel is attending a social media conference in San Francisco. She is presenting a speech about her company's use of YouTube for customer service training. In addition, she has attended workshops on ethics regarding the use of social media in the workplace, how to target audience demographics through social media, and the development of new social media channels of communication. To bring her colleagues up to date on her experiences at the conference, Sanya can write on her company's Facebook wall, send a tweet, post a blog entry, or make a YouTube video.

Assignment

Explain the benefits and drawbacks for each of Sanya's options. Then, write the text for Sanya, using the social media option that you consider best. Create any additional text you would like to complete this task.

WEB WORKSHOP

1. Bloggers provide up-to-date information on newsbreaking events and ideas.
 - For e-commerce news, visit <http://blog.clickz.com/> (ClickZ Network—Solution for Marketers).
 - For business blogging, visit http://www.businessweek.com/the_thread/blogspotting/ (Business Week Online) to learn where the “worlds of business, media and blogs collide.”
 - For technology news (information technology, computer information systems, biomedical informatics, and more), visit <http://blogs.zdnet.com/>. Once in this site, use their search engine to find a technology topic that interests you.
 - Every news agency, such as ABC, NBC, CBS, CNBC, has a news blog.
To see what’s new in your field of interest, check out a blog. Then, report key findings to your instructor in an e-mail message.
2. There are many published guidelines for accepted use of social media. Review the following links to learn what these guidelines entail. Then write an e-mail message to your professor reporting your findings.
 - “Social Media Guide’s Top 10 Twitter Tips.” <http://mashable.com/2009/06/25/twitter-seo-tips/>
 - “IBM Social Computing Guidelines: Blogs, wikis, social networks, virtual worlds and social media.” <http://www.ibm.com/blogs/zz/en/guidelines.html>
 - “Sun Microsystems’s Guidelines on Public Discourse.” <http://www.sun.com/communities/guidelines.jsp>
 - “Intel Social Media Guidelines.” www.intel.com/sites/sitewide/en_us/social-media.htm

TEXT CREDITS

Credits are listed in order of appearance.

Figure 1 — Sample Blog. Courtesy of Spiral 16.

Figure 2 — YouTube Screen. Courtesy of Spiral 16 and YouTube.

Figure 4 — Sample Twitter Page. Courtesy of Spiral 16.

Figure 6 — Listing for a Blog entry. Courtesy of Spiral 16.

Figure 7 — Whitney's Draft of the Blog Entry with her Thoughts on Revision. Courtesy of Whitney Mathews.

Figure 8 — Whitney's Blog Entry for Spiral16. Courtesy of Whitney Mathews.

PHOTO CREDITS

Credits are listed in order of appearance.

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